very resonant'. For both Murad and Daniyal this fatal mix of their father's own soaring achievements, his impossible expectations of them, combined with a beguiling and increasingly luxurious courtly life, would result in their undoing and both would succumb to alcoholism early in life.

But these early years for the princes were undoubtedly a time of indulgence and joy. Almost every day there were new celebrations and innovations as the masons and craftsmen constructed a vision in red sandstone all around them. In 1573, following Akbar's great victories in Gujarat, Haji Begum came to court from Delhi to congratulate her stepson and there was a grand banquet. These great celebrations would become increasingly elaborate as the years went by while the etiquette surrounding the Padshah's every meal also gained in spectacle and was meticulously described a few years later by Monserrate:

> His table is very sumptuous, generally consisting of more than forty courses served in great dishes. These are brought into the royal dining hall covered and wrapped in linen cloths, which are tied up and sealed by the cook for fear of poison. They are carried by youths to the door of the dining hall, other servants walking ahead and the master of the household following. Here they are taken over by eunuchs, who hand them to the serving girls who wait on the royal table.

Supplying these gargantuan meals was the imperial kitchen, a department consisting of a head cook, a treasurer, a storekeeper, clerks, tasters, and more than 400 cooks from all over India and Persia. According to food historian Salma Husain, the hakim (royal physician) planned each menu to include medicinally beneficial ingredients. Each grain of rice for the biryani was coated with silver oil, which aided digestion and acted as an aphrodisiac. According to historian Lizzie Collingham, biryani itself was a fragrant and fortuitous Mughal mix of delicately flavoured Persian pilau and the pungent and spicy rice dishes of Hindustan. Ice, for the cooling of drinks and making frozen desserts, was brought daily from the Himalayas by an elaborate system of couriers.

Some of the food served at banquets, in dishes of gold, silver, stone, and earthenware, would have included yakhni, a meat stock; musamman, stuffed roast chicken; dopiaza, meat prepared with large quantities of onions; dampukht, meat cooked slowly with aromatic spices in a pot with a